

Jamiatul Ulama Johannesburg

الاعتكاف: الدليل الحنفي الكامل I'tikāf: The Complete Ḥanafī Guide

PDF · 24 pages · Ḥanafī School



وما علينا إلا البلاغ المبين

"Clear propagation is our only responsibility." — Sūrah Yāsīn 36:17

Definition and Ruling

التعريف والحكم

"I'tikāf is a Sunnah mu'akkadah 'alal-kifāyah — if performed by even one person in a locality, the obligation is lifted from the rest."

I'tikāf () is the spiritual retreat within a masjid, wherein a Muslim secludes himself for the purpose of worship, reflection, and devotion to Allah. Its essential pillar (rukn) is staying (labth) in the masjid with the intention of I'tikāf.

The ruling of I'tikāf in the last ten nights of Ramaḍān is Sunnah mu'akkadah 'alal-kifāyah — a confirmed Sunnah, sufficient if performed by at least one person in a locality. If no one performs it, the entire community is sinful. Outside of Ramaḍān, I'tikāf is a recommended (nafl) act that may be performed at any time.

Source: Al-Hidāyah, Margīnānī · Radd al-Muḥtār, Ibn 'Ābidīn



Conditions of Validity

شروط الصحة

The conditions (shurūṭ) for a valid I'tikāf are:

1. Islam — non-Muslims cannot perform I'tikāf.
2. Sanity ('aql) — the insane and unconscious cannot intend.
3. Intention (niyyah) — the heart must intend the act for Allah's sake.
4. Being in a masjid — for men, this is obligatory; for women, in her designated prayer space at home.
5. For the Sunnah I'tikāf of Ramaḍān: in a masjid where the five daily Ṣalāh are held in congregation (jamā'ah). A muṣallā not formally designated as a masjid does not fulfil this.
6. Purity from major ritual impurity (janābah, ḥaiḍ, nifās) — one must enter I'tikāf in a state of wudū.

The woman in ḥaiḍ or nifās cannot perform I'tikāf; if it begins during I'tikāf, she must leave the masjid.

Source: Fatāwā Hindiyyah, Vol. 1 · Al-Durr al-Mukhtār



The Sunnah Period

الوقت المسنون

The Sunnah period of I'tikāf is the last ten nights of Ramaḍān — entering the masjid before sunset (ghurūb) on the 20th of Ramaḍān, and remaining until the moon of Eid al-Fiṭr is sighted.

The Prophet ﷺ established this practice. 'Ā'ishah رضي الله عنها reported: "The Prophet ﷺ used to practise I'tikāf in the last ten days of Ramaḍān until Allah took him, and then his wives practised I'tikāf after him." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2026, Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1172)

Nafl I'tikāf may be performed at any time, even for a short duration. The minimum is a moment of intention while in the masjid.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2026 · Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1172



What Nullifies I'tikāf

مبطلات الاعتكاف

The following nullify (mubṭilāt) the I'tikāf:

1. Leaving the masjid without a valid Shar'ī reason. Valid reasons include: using the toilet, making wudū, eating if food cannot be brought inside, attending to a genuine necessity (e.g. medical emergency). One must return immediately after completing the necessity.
2. Marital relations (jimā') or any act that leads to it.
3. Apostasy (may Allah protect us).
4. Loss of consciousness due to illness, intoxication, or fainting for an extended period.

Leaving for a valid reason must be only for the necessary duration. To linger beyond what is needed nullifies the I'tikāf.

Source: Radd al-Muḥtār · Baḥr al-Rā'iq



Recommended Practices

الآداب والمستحبات

The following are recommended (mustahabb) during I'tikāf:

1. Increase in recitation of the Qur'ān. The Salaf used to complete the Qur'ān multiple times during I'tikāf.
2. Abundant dhikr — including tasbīḥ (), taḥmīd (), tahlīl (), and takbīr ().
3. Send blessings (ṣalawāt) upon the Prophet frequently.
4. Engage in sincere du'ā — especially in the last ten nights, seeking Laylat al-Qadr.
5. Avoid vain talk, arguments, and worldly chatter.
6. Eat, drink, and sleep inside the masjid with proper adab — maintaining its sanctity.
7. Avoid backbiting, gossip, and any speech that would diminish the reward of the I'tikāf.

Source: Iḥyā' 'Ulūm al-Dīn, Ghazālī · Fatāwā Maḥmūdiyyah



Laylat al-Qadr and I'tikāf

ليلة القدر والاعتكاف

إنا أنزلناه في ليلة القدر ﴿١﴾ وما أدراك ما ليلة القدر ﴿٢﴾ ليلة القدر خير من ألف شهر

Laylat al-Qadr (the Night of Power) is the crowning night of I'tikāf. Allah says: "We have indeed revealed this in the Night of Power. And what will explain to you what the Night of Power is? The Night of Power is better than a thousand months." (Sūrah al-Qadr 97:1-3)

The Prophet said: "Seek Laylat al-Qadr in the odd nights of the last ten nights of Ramaḍān." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2017)

The odd nights are the 21st, 23rd, 25th, 27th, and 29th. The most emphasized is the 27th, though the matter is not certain. The du'ā of 'Ā'ishah should be made: "Allāhumma innaka 'afuwwun, tuḥibbul-'afwa, fa'fu 'annī" (O Allah, You are Pardoning, and You love to pardon, so pardon me). (Sunan al-Tirmidhī 3513)

Source: Sūrah al-Qadr 97:1-3 · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2017 · Sunan al-Tirmidhī 3513



Common Errors to Avoid

أخطاء شائعة

1. Leaving the masjid unnecessarily — even for "a quick chat" or social media. This nullifies the I'tikāf.
2. Performing I'tikāf in a muṣallā not designated as a masjid — does not fulfil the Sunnah requirement.
3. Excessive phone use, including for permissible activities — defeats the purpose of seclusion.
4. Treating I'tikāf as a "sleep-away camp" — the Sunnah is worship, not rest.
5. Talking loudly or disturbing others in the masjid.
6. Neglecting the congregational Ṣalāh — the one in I'tikāf must attend every congregational prayer in that masjid.
7. Bringing in food with strong odours that may disturb other worshippers.

Source: Classical Ḥanafī Fatāwā collections



جمعية العلماء جوهانسبرغ

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